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STUDY GUIDE FOR



UNITED NATIONS WOMEN

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UNITED NATIONS WOMEN (UNW)

INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMITTEE

UN Women was established in 2010 through the General Assembly's institutional consolidation of UN work on women's rights and gender equality. It supports intergovernmental processes, helps countries translate global commitments into policy, coordinates UN-system work on gender equality and provides technical and normative support. Its work is guided by instruments including CEDAW, the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, the 2030 Agenda and the UN Women Strategic Plan 2026–2029.



1. Mandate of the United Nations Women

United Nations Women was established in July 2010 through United Nations General Assembly Resolution 64/289, bringing together four previously separate entities to strengthen the promotion of gender equality and the empowerment of women. Its mandate is centered on advancing women's rights, eliminating discrimination, and protecting women from exploitation in all spheres of life, including matters related to health, reproduction, and bodily autonomy.

The organization supports intergovernmental bodies in setting global standards, assists member states in implementing policies, and ensures accountability across the United Nations system regarding gender equality commitments. While commercial surrogacy is not directly regulated at the international level, it falls under the broader mandate of United Nations Women because it directly involves questions of reproductive autonomy, women's health, and potential exploitation.

Frameworks such as the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995), the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (1979), and the International Conference on Population and Development Programme of Action (1994) affirm women's right to make decisions regarding their reproductive lives free of coercion or abuse.

Within this context, United Nations Women's mandate extends to monitoring how practices like global commercial surrogacy impact women, ensuring that reproductive autonomy is protected while also preventing the commodification and exploitation of women's bodies.

Through its work with the General Assembly, the Commission on the Status of Women, and other United Nations entities, United Nations Women promotes international cooperation and guides states in addressing the ethical and legal challenges posed by surrogacy. Its mandate therefore provides the foundation for examining global commercial surrogacy both as a matter of reproductive rights and as a potential site of exploitation requiring careful international attention.

2. Funding of the United Nations Women

United Nations Women is financed through a combination of assessed contributions, voluntary donations, and inter-agency support within the United Nations system. Unlike certain United Nations bodies that operate primarily on assessed contributions from member states, United Nations Women relies heavily on voluntary contributions provided by governments, intergovernmental organizations, private sector partners, and individuals.

The United Nations regular budget, which is made up of assessed contributions from all member states, provides a limited allocation to United Nations Women, mainly to cover its core functions and staff. However, the vast majority of the organization's operational and programmatic activities are funded through voluntary contributions, making sustained donor support critical for its work.

To ensure predictability and accountability, United Nations Women administers a multi-year funding framework, aligning contributions with the priorities outlined in its Strategic Plans. These resources are distributed across its global initiatives, including the advancement of women's rights, support for national legislation and policies, and the implementation of gender equality commitments at country and regional levels.

A key funding instrument is the United Nations Trust Fund to End Violence against Women, managed by United Nations Women since 1996, which provides grants to initiatives worldwide aimed at preventing and responding to gender-based violence. Other earmarked funds are dedicated to areas such as women's political participation, economic empowerment, and humanitarian response.

The financial reports of United Nations Women consistently highlight the imbalance between the organization's expanding mandate and the level of resources available, underscoring the need for broader and more consistent financial support from member states and donors. Adequate and sustainable funding is therefore essential for United Nations Women to effectively address global issues such as commercial surrogacy, ensuring that women's reproductive rights are upheld while protecting against potential exploitation.

AGENDA

ADDRESSING THE DIGITAL GENDER DIVIDE AND TECHNOLOGY-FACILITATED GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE

1.1. Introduction to the Agenda

The digital gender divide

The divide should be understood as more than a connectivity statistic. A woman may technically have internet access while lacking a private device, affordable data, digital literacy, confidence, accessible content, a safe environment, or the ability to use technology independently. This distinction matters because policies that measure only subscriptions or coverage can report progress while leaving the underlying inequality largely unchanged.

The divide is also shaped by location and social position. Rural women may face weak infrastructure; low-income women may ration data; women with disabilities may encounter inaccessible interfaces; and women living under restrictive social conditions may technically have connectivity while facing family or community restrictions on its use. A strong analysis therefore asks not simply who is connected, but who can use digital tools meaningfully, safely and autonomously.

The digital gender divide is not one gap. It includes whether a person can obtain a device, afford connectivity, access electricity, possess relevant skills, use services safely, understand privacy controls, participate in digital economies and have meaningful opportunities to shape technology. A woman may technically be “online” while still being digitally excluded through cost, poor quality access, social restrictions or harassment.

Technology-facilitated gender-based violence

UN Women describes technology-facilitated violence as harmful acts committed, assisted, aggravated or amplified through digital tools, producing or potentially producing physical, sexual, psychological, social, political or economic harm. It can also occur offline through technology, such as GPS-enabled surveillance.

Forms of TFGBV & the Technology Behind Them

A spectrum rather than isolated incidents

TFGBV can range from repeated unwanted messages to coordinated campaigns involving many accounts, manipulated media, financial abuse and offline threats. The same victim may experience several forms simultaneously.

- Harassment and threats: repeated insults, sexualized abuse, threats of rape or physical harm.
- Doxing and exposure: publishing addresses, phone numbers, workplaces or family information.
- Impersonation: fake accounts, fraudulent profiles or identity misuse.
- Non-consensual intimate imagery: real or synthetic sexual content distributed without consent.
- Deepfakes and synthetic sexual content: AI lowers the cost of creating realistic fake media.
- Cyberstalking and surveillance: tracking location, devices, accounts or communications.
- Gendered disinformation: coordinated narratives portraying women as immoral, incompetent, dangerous or sexually available.
- Financial abuse: unauthorized purchases, account takeover, payment manipulation or employment-related sabotage.

Why AI changes the policy problem

Artificial intelligence changes the scale and speed of digital abuse. Generative systems can produce convincing synthetic text, images, audio and video at very low cost, while automated accounts can amplify material across multiple platforms. This creates a governance problem in which the harm may spread faster than a victim can report it and may cross several jurisdictions before a remedy is available.



AI also complicates evidence. A manipulated image may be false while still causing real reputational, professional or psychological harm. The policy challenge is therefore not simply to prohibit “deepfakes,” but to balance prevention, detection, evidence preservation, rapid remedies, privacy, due process and freedom of expression. UN Women’s current strategy places technology-facilitated violence within the wider continuum of violence against women and emphasizes norms, data, digital ecosystems, survivor-centred justice and women’s agency.

1.2. Key Terminologies Related to the Agenda

- Cyberstalking: persistent digital monitoring, unwanted contact or tracking that causes fear or harm.
- Doxing: publishing private or identifying information without consent, often to facilitate harassment.
- Image-based abuse: non-consensual creation, sharing or distribution of intimate or sexualized images.
- Deepfake: synthetic media generated or altered using AI; sexualized deepfakes disproportionately target women.
- Gendered disinformation: false or manipulated narratives that exploit gender stereotypes to silence or discredit women.
- Online sexual harassment: unwanted sexualized communication or conduct through digital channels.
- Digital coercive control: using accounts, devices, passwords, location data or surveillance tools to control a person.
- Digital literacy: the ability to access, understand, evaluate, create and safely use digital information and tools.
- Sextortion: coercion or extortion in which a perpetrator threatens to distribute intimate images or information unless the target complies with a demand, such as money, further images or continued contact.
- Algorithmic amplification: the way recommendation and ranking systems can spread harmful, harassing content because it drives engagement, independent of any single user's intent.

- Digital identity theft/impersonation: creating a fake account or profile, or taking over an existing one, to misrepresent, harass or defraud in a person's name.

CONCEPTUAL DISTINCTION

Not every harmful online act is TFGBV. The gender dimension becomes central when the harm is directed at someone because of gender, sexualized, rooted in gender inequality, or disproportionately experienced by women and girls.

1.3. Historical Context

The history of this agenda item is best understood as three overlapping waves of international attention, each building on the last rather than replacing it.

The first wave established the underlying architecture of women's rights within the UN system, long before "digital" was part of the vocabulary. The UN Charter (1945) and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948) laid the normative groundwork for equality between men and women. The Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) followed quickly, established by ECOSOC resolution 11(II) in 1946 as the principal global intergovernmental body dedicated to gender equality — making it one of the oldest functional commissions in the UN system. Three World Conferences on Women followed over the next three decades: Mexico City (1975), Copenhagen (1980) and Nairobi (1985), each expanding the international consensus on women's rights. The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) was adopted in 1979 and remains the core binding human-rights treaty on this agenda, obligating states parties to take "all appropriate measures" to eliminate discrimination against women in all its forms.

The second wave crystallized at the Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing in September 1995, which produced the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action. Beijing remains the most comprehensive global policy framework on gender equality ever adopted, organized around twelve critical areas of concern, including violence against women, women and the media, education and training, and power and decision-making.



The third wave is institutional consolidation and the shift from "access" to "safety." In 2010, the General Assembly adopted resolution 64/289, merging four previously separate UN gender bodies — the UN Development Fund for Women (UNIFEM), the Division for the Advancement of Women, the Office of the Special Adviser on Gender Issues, and the UN International Research and Training Institute for the Advancement of Women — into a single composite entity, UN Women, which became operational on 1 January 2011 under founding Executive Director Michelle Bachelet. This consolidation gave gender equality work a single normative voice within the UN system for the first time.

Through the 2000s and 2010s, as ICTs became central to education, employment and political participation, the international conversation shifted from formal rights toward measurable connectivity and skills gaps — the "digital gender divide" as a distinct policy problem. Then, starting roughly in the mid-2010s, the same technologies that were closing (or failing to close) that access gap were increasingly recognized as new vectors of harm. The CEDAW Committee's General Recommendation No. 35 (2017), updating the founding General Recommendation No. 19 (1992), was the pivotal normative moment: it explicitly extended "gender-based violence against women" to technology-mediated environments, describing violence as a continuum spanning private, public and digital settings alike.

2025 marked a hinge point that any delegate should treat as the live, current-session anchor for this agenda. It was the thirtieth anniversary of Beijing, and the Commission used its 69th session (CSW69, 10–21 March 2025) to conduct a formal review of implementation. For the first time, a CSW political declaration explicitly referenced gender-based violence occurring in cyberspace, and UN Women launched the Beijing+30 Action Agenda alongside it — a roadmap built on national review input from 159 Member States. Later that year, UN Women's UNiTE campaign for the 16 Days of Activism against Gender-Based Violence adopted digital violence against women and girls as its dedicated focus. Read together, the historical arc runs from formal equality (1945–1979), to comprehensive policy framework (1995), to institutional consolidation (2010), to recognition of technology-facilitated violence as a treaty-scope issue (2017), to the current moment of translating thirty years of recognition into resourced, measurable digital-era action (2024–2025).



1.4. Relevant International and Regional Frameworks

International Frameworks

CEDAW

CEDAW provides the broader human-rights foundation for examining discrimination against women, including discrimination that is reproduced through institutions, social practices and unequal access to opportunities. Although CEDAW predates the modern internet, its principles can be applied to contemporary forms of inequality when digital systems affect women's access to education, employment, public participation, services or justice.

For this agenda, the important conceptual point is that digital policy should not be treated as gender-neutral simply because the technology itself is neutral in design. If women experience systematically different barriers or harms, States can examine whether existing equality and non-discrimination obligations are being effectively implemented in the digital environment.

The Beijing Platform for Action

The digital agenda has subsequently required those principles to be translated into new contexts: who has access to digital information, who controls technology, whose voices are amplified or silenced, how women are represented online, and what remedies exist when technology is weaponized against them. The Beijing Platform is especially relevant to violence against women, education and training, women and the media, human rights and institutional mechanisms.

2030 Agenda

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, adopted by the General Assembly in September 2015, embeds gender equality across several interlinked goals rather than treating it as a single silo.

- SDG 5: gender equality and empowerment.
- SDG 4: education and digital skills.
- SDG 8: decent work and economic participation.
- SDG 9: resilient infrastructure and innovation.
- SDG 10: reduced inequalities.
- SDG 16: peace, justice and strong institutions.
- SDG 17: partnerships and implementation

Regional Frameworks:

The normative frameworks above set out rights and principles; the following national and regional platform-accountability laws show how several States have already begun translating those principles into enforceable rules that touch directly on technology-facilitated violence against women. Delegates can cite these as existing precedents rather than asking the Council to invent regulatory concepts from nothing.

- **European Union:** the Digital Services Act entered into force on 16 November 2022 and became directly applicable across all EU member states from 17 February 2024, imposing risk-assessment, due-diligence and transparency obligations on large platforms, including obligations relevant to gender-based online abuse.
- **United Kingdom:** the Online Safety Act 2023 received royal assent on 26 October 2023 and is being brought into force in phases by Ofcom, with illegal-content and child-safety duties enforceable from early 2024; it creates statutory duties of care covering harassment and intimate-image abuse.
- **Australia:** the Online Safety Act 2021 commenced on 23 January 2022 and gives the eSafety Commissioner, in place since 2015, a statutory adult cyber-abuse complaints scheme and an image-based abuse scheme allowing victims to seek removal of non-consensual intimate images.
- **India:** the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, notified on 25 February 2021, require intermediaries to operate a grievance-redressal mechanism and, for large platforms, to enable traceability of the first originator of certain flagged content.

The variation among these frameworks is itself instructive for delegates: some rely on statutory duties of care enforced by a dedicated regulator (UK, Australia), others on horizontal due-diligence obligations applied across a whole trading bloc (EU), and others on intermediary-liability rules tied to an existing IT statute (India). A resolution does not need to endorse any single model, but citing more than one shows the committee that platform accountability is achievable through several different legal architectures, which strengthens the case that a proposed mechanism is realistic rather than aspirational.

1.5. Core Principles

A resolution on this agenda is judged not by how much sympathy it expresses but by how faithfully it operationalizes a small set of recurring principles drawn from CEDAW, the Beijing Platform, the Global Digital Compact and UN Women's own guidance. Six principles should anchor every clause.

Non-discrimination and substantive equality. CEDAW's central legal concept is that formally equal treatment is not enough; states must achieve equality of outcome, not merely equality of opportunity on paper. Applied to this agenda, this means a country cannot claim compliance simply because internet access is technically available to women — if women systematically cannot use it safely, affordably or independently, substantive equality has not been achieved.

The continuum of violence. General Recommendation No. 35 rejects the idea that "online" and "offline" violence are separate categories requiring separate policy logics. Instead, it frames technology-facilitated abuse as an extension of the same continuum of violence that occurs in the home, the workplace and public life. This matters for drafting: a resolution that treats cyberstalking as unrelated to intimate-partner violence, for instance, will miss that the same coercive-control dynamic often operates through both channels simultaneously.

Survivor-centred response. A reporting mechanism is not successful merely because it exists or receives complaints. The relevant test is whether survivors can safely report, understand the process, obtain timely and meaningful remedies, and avoid retaliation or re-traumatization. This principle should discipline any clause that proposes a "hotline," "reporting portal," or "grievance mechanism" — the existence of the mechanism is not the outcome; the survivor's actual experience of it is.

Intersectionality. Risk and access barriers compound across age, disability, income, race and ethnicity, migration status, sexual orientation, rural location and public visibility. A rural, low-income woman with a disability does not face "the digital divide" in the same way as an urban professional woman; a uniform, one-size-fits-all policy can therefore produce very unequal real-world outcomes even when it appears neutral on its face.

Rights-respecting proportionality. Safety measures must be balanced against privacy, due process, encryption and freedom of expression, not pursued through unrestricted surveillance or vague content bans that could criminalize legitimate speech. The Global Digital Compact explicitly frames digital safety and human-rights protection as complementary obligations, not competing ones — a resolution should show it understands this is a balance to be struck, not a binary choice.

Evidence and accountability. Commitments are only as strong as the ability to verify them. Every substantive clause should be paired with disaggregated, sex-specific data, a named implementing actor, and a measurable indicator — echoing the Global Digital Compact's call for comparable, sex-disaggregated methodologies to track digital-inclusion and safety commitments across states. UN Women's 2025 findings that only around 57 per cent of needed gender data is currently available, and that just one in four countries can report how much they spend on gender equality, illustrate why this principle cannot be treated as a technical footnote: without comparable measurement, "accountability" clauses are unenforceable by construction, regardless of how strongly they are worded.

Together, these six principles function less as a checklist and more as a set of cross-checks delegates can apply to any proposed clause. A safety measure that ignores proportionality risks becoming a surveillance mandate; a data clause that ignores intersectionality risks measuring the wrong population; a platform-accountability clause that ignores the continuum of violence risks treating online harm as disconnected from the offline abuse it often accompanies.

1.6. Contemporary Case Studies and Violations

Case Study 1 — Women in public life

Women journalists, politicians, activists and human-rights defenders can face coordinated online abuse intended not merely to insult but to drive them out of public participation. UN Women research emphasizes that online violence can spill into offline threats and affect women's safety, well-being and participation.

Case Study 2 — Girls and synthetic sexual content

A student whose face is placed onto explicit synthetic media can face school exclusion, family pressure, reputational harm and threats even when the content is entirely fabricated. The policy lesson is that a criminal definition based only on “real intimate material” can leave victims without an effective remedy.

Case Study 3 — Intimate-partner digital control

An abusive partner may demand passwords, monitor location, inspect messages, install tracking applications or use shared cloud accounts to maintain control. The case demonstrates why TFGBV cannot be treated only as a platform-moderation issue; survivor services, domestic-violence systems, police training and digital-security assistance are also necessary.

Intersectionality

Risk can be intensified by age, disability, poverty, race/ethnicity, migration status, sexuality, rural location or public visibility. A universal policy may therefore produce unequal outcomes. Resolutions should require disaggregated data and accessible reporting mechanisms without forcing survivors to disclose unnecessary personal information.

1.7. Challenges in the Implementation and Enforcement

- **Lack of International Regulation:**

The central obstacle facing this agenda is not a shortage of normative language; CEDAW, Beijing, the Global Digital Compact and multiple CSW outcomes already articulate the relevant rights and goals in considerable detail. The obstacle is a persistent, and in some respects worsening, gap between what has been agreed and what is actually resourced, and enforced.

Financing is the most acute of these gaps. UN Women's Gender Snapshot 2025, produced jointly with UN DESA, found an annual financing shortfall of roughly USD 420 billion for gender equality efforts in developing countries. This is not abstract: a separate 2025 UN Women study found that one in three organizations working to end violence against women had suspended or programmes due to funding cuts, and several major donors reduced or withdrew support for gender-focused UN programmes during the year, showing how quickly formally agreed financing commitments can be reversed.

Shrinking civic space compounds this. Drawing on over 150 government submissions to its 2024–2025 stocktake, UN Women found that nearly one in four countries reported a backlash against women's rights actively undermining implementation, part of a broader pattern of democratic backsliding, conflict and economic insecurity. For delegates, this means a resolution's ambition can be undercut not just by lack of resources but by active political resistance in the states meant to implement it.

Measurement is a related challenge: funding cuts to national statistical systems mean only around 57 per cent of the data needed to track gender-equality progress is currently available, so neither the Commission nor Member States can reliably verify whether commitments are being met — leaving accountability mechanisms largely symbolic.



Jurisdictional fragmentation adds another layer. A single incident of technology-facilitated abuse can span a perpetrator, victim, platform and payment processor in different legal systems, while the Global Digital Compact's trust-and-safety provisions remain aspirational rather than binding. Enforcement currently depends on uneven national legislation — the EU's Digital Services Act, the UK's and Australia's Online Safety Acts, and India's IT Intermediary Guidelines are the most developed examples, but most states have no comparable framework.

Finally, generative AI is advancing faster than either platform moderation or policy drafting can keep pace with: sexualized deepfakes can be produced and distributed across borders almost instantly, meaning narrowly worded, technology-specific rules risk becoming obsolete before they are even implemented.

1.8. The Way Forward: Proposed Measures and Recommendations

The clearest current roadmap available to delegates is the Beijing+30 Action Agenda, launched by UN Women at CSW69 in March 2025 and built on national review input from 159 Member States. It organizes future action around six priorities — a digital revolution, freedom from poverty, zero violence, full and equal decision-making power, peace and security, and climate justice — underpinned by two cross-cutting foundations, financing and gender data, with adolescent girls and young women placed at the centre of implementation. This gives a resolution a ready-made, already-negotiated framework to build on rather than requiring an entirely new architecture.

UN Women's UNiTE campaign operationalized this in 2025 by making digital violence against women and girls its focus for the 16 Days of Activism, explicitly framing the issue as a shared responsibility across governments, platforms, UN entities and funders rather than any single actor's task.

Concrete near-term priorities for a resolution:

- **Close the gender data gap first — resource national surveys and adopt the comparable, sex-disaggregated methodologies called for in the Global Digital Compact, so progress can actually be verified.**
- **Adapt existing national models rather than reinventing them — safety-by-design duties, mandatory transparency reporting, and rapid-response channels for image-based abuse, as already codified in the EU's Digital Services Act, the UK's and Australia's Online Safety Acts, and India's intermediary rules.**
- **Build in AI-specific safeguards now — content provenance/watermarking standards, independent risk audits of generative-AI systems, and rapid de-indexing procedures with due-process-compliant appeals.**
- **Treat financing as foundational, not a closing clause — specify who pays, through what mechanism (UN trust funds, gender-responsive national budgeting, safeguarded public-private partnerships), and how compliance is reviewed over time.**
- **Distribute responsibility realistically — states legislate and fund; platforms redesign products and report transparently; civil society monitors and delivers survivor services; UN Women convenes and provides technical guidance.**
- **Anchor every clause in the existing textual record — the 2025 CSW69 political declaration, the Beijing+30 Action Agenda, and the Global Digital Compact, so the resolution accelerates commitments already made rather than asking states to accept an untested new mandate.**

1.9. QARMA – Questions a Resolution Must Answer

- 1. How does the delegation define the gendered digital divide beyond simple access to the internet, particularly in relation to affordability, digital literacy, online safety, algorithmic discrimination, and women's ability to meaningfully participate in digital spaces?**
- 2. Which groups of women and girls—including those in rural areas, conflict-affected regions, low-income communities, and marginalized populations—face the greatest barriers to digital participation, and what concrete mechanisms does the delegation propose to ensure that international policy does not leave these groups further behind?**
- 3. Where does the delegation place responsibility when gender-based digital harm occurs: with national governments, technology companies, social-media platforms, users, or international institutions—and how should responsibility be divided when multiple actors contribute to the harm?**
- 4. How can Member States combat online gender-based violence and technology-facilitated abuse without creating vague or excessively broad regulations that could be misused to suppress legitimate political speech, journalism, activism, or women's rights advocacy?**
- 5. What safeguards does the delegation propose to ensure that measures addressing online harassment, intimate-image abuse, doxxing, and other forms of technology-facilitated violence protect survivors' privacy and dignity while simultaneously guaranteeing due process and preventing arbitrary censorship?**
- 6. Should social-media and technology companies merely be encouraged to address gender-based digital harms, or should Member States establish legally binding obligations requiring platforms to assess risks, remove unlawful content, provide transparent reporting mechanisms, and disclose how their algorithms may disproportionately affect women and girls?**
- 7. If a Member State criminalizes online gender-based violence but lacks independent judicial institutions, transparent enforcement mechanisms, or adequate survivor-protection systems, how can the international community distinguish genuine protection of women from legislation that merely expands state control over digital speech?**

- 8. As generative AI, deepfakes, automated recommendation systems, and increasingly sophisticated synthetic media develop faster than many regulatory frameworks, how does the delegation propose identifying and addressing emerging forms of gender-based harm without relying on legislation that becomes obsolete as soon as the technology evolves?**
- 9. Who should bear the financial responsibility for implementing international measures against gender-based digital harm, particularly when lower-income states may lack the resources to establish reporting systems, digital-literacy programs, survivor-support services, and specialized law-enforcement capabilities?**
- 10. What measurable indicators should UN Women and Member States use to determine whether their policies are actually reducing gender-based digital harm and expanding women's meaningful digital participation, and what mechanism should exist when a state or platform repeatedly fails to meet those benchmarks?**

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